SAMPLE

Uzair: The Question of the Hundred Years

The Named One of 9:30 and the Man of the Hundred Years

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Introduction: A Name in One Verse

Some figures of the Quran fill pages; Uzair fills a verse -- and the tradition built a book of questions around him anyway. His name appears once in the Book: "And the Jews said: Uzair is the son of Allah, and the Christians said: the Messiah is the son of Allah. That is their saying with their mouths, imitating the saying of those who disbelieved before them. Allah fight them! How they are turned away!" (9:30). One verse -- and in it, one of the Book's sharpest theological rulings: the refutation of the son-of-Allah claim, placed in the same sentence structure for two communities, with the exclamation that is among the Quran's strongest: qatalahum Allah, "may Allah fight them."

And beside the named verse stands the unnamed scene: "Or the one who passed by a town in ruins and said: How will Allah revive this after its death? So Allah made him die a hundred years, then raised him..." (2:259) -- the man of the hundred years, whose question about the resurrection was answered with a century of sleep and a donkey's bones; and the classical tradition, from the earliest commentators onward, reportedly identified the man as Uzair -- the same Uzair the later communities would call a son of Allah, honored in the Book as the asker of the resurrection's question and the witness of the resurrection's proof.

This book studies both passages -- the named claim and the unnamed scene -- and the figure the tradition reads across them: Uzair, the scribe of the restoration in the earlier tradition's memory, the asker of the resurrection in the Quran's scene, and the named one of the verse that rules the son-of-Allah saying out of the faith. The book follows the series' method: the Quran first, the identification second (reported as a reading), the commentary third, and no speculation beyond the sources -- a method this figure needs more than most, because the distance between one named verse and a whole book is the distance this book exists to cross honestly. The crossing is made on the two verses' own riches: the parable's scene is among the Book's fullest demonstrations, and the claim-verse's theology is among the Book's sharpest rulings -- and the book's chapters walk the riches in order: the claim, the parable, the century, the bones, the confession, the identification, the scribe-memory, the theology, the commentators, the doctrine's map, and the believer's own share in the lessons of a figure the Book named once and the tradition remembered honestly.

The book is part of the Honored Ones sub-series of the NurOne master series by Aira Aurora. It follows the series' books on the figures the Quran honors -- Maryam, Asiya, Hajar, Luqman, Dhul-Qarnayn, the Mother of Musa, Khadijah, Al-Khidr -- and adds the honored one whose honor is the question he asked: the question the Lord answered with a hundred years, and answered, in the same Book, with the verse that guards the tawhid against every claim of a son.

Chapter 1: The Verse of 9:30 -- The Saying and the Answer

"And the Jews said: Uzair is the son of Allah, and the Christians said: the Messiah is the son of Allah. That is their saying with their mouths, imitating the saying of those who disbelieved before them. Allah fight them! How they are turned away!" (9:30).

The verse sits in the Surah of Tawbah -- the surah of the clarion, the surah without the basmalah, the surah that opens the accounts of the covenant-breakers and closes the doors the earlier surahs had left open. And in the surah's middle, the verse of the two claims: the two communities' sayings about sons -- Uzair for the one, the Messiah for the other -- named in the same breath, refuted in the same breath, and condemned with the exclamation that needs no translation across the centuries: the Lord's own astonishment at the turning away.

The verse's structure is the refutation's anatomy. First the two sayings are reported -- plainly, without commentary, in the words the communities used. Then the diagnosis: "That is their saying with their mouths" -- the saying is a mouth-saying, a form of speech without a ground in the reality; and "imitating the saying of those who disbelieved before them" -- the claim is not an original error but an inherited one, the pattern of the earlier nations' god-talk applied to new names. Then the ruling: "Allah fight them!" -- the Quran's strongest exclamation against the distorters of the tawhid. And then the wonder: "How they are turned away!" -- the amazement at the turning: the people of the Book, who had the Book, turned from the tawhid their own Book taught to the saying the Book never taught.

The pairing teaches. The verse does not refute the Christian claim alone, or the Jewish claim alone, but the pair --

because the error is one error: the ascription of sonship to the Lord, whoever the son is named to be. The Quran's tawhid is not the denial of one community's excess; it is the denial of the category: "He begets not, nor was He begotten, and none is comparable to Him" (112:3-4). The verse of Uzair is one of the Book's rulings in the category's case law: the son named Uzair and the son named Messiah stand in the same sentence because they stand in the same error -- and the believer learns the verse's lesson beyond its two named examples: every son-of-god saying of every age is the same saying with the same mouth, and the refutation of 9:30 is the refutation of the form.

And the verse's precision protects the man it names. The verse does not say Uzair claimed to be a son of Allah, nor that Uzair taught the claim -- the verse reports the saying of the community: "the Jews said." The tradition's honest reading holds the distinction: the claim is the community's later saying, and the verse condemns the saying, not the named man's own teaching -- for the Quran, elsewhere, honors the asker of the resurrection's question, and the tradition's identification of that asker as Uzair, if it holds, means the Book's own scenes place the man among the taught, not among the teachers of the error. The believer reads 9:30 with the verse's own aim: the claim is condemned, the claimers are warned, and the named one's own account belongs to the Lord who named him.

The verse of the claim sits among the surah's verses on the People of the Book -- the passage that distinguishes the covenant-keepers from the distortion-makers: "It is not that they turned away from the Jews and the Christians until they have... " and the passage's own distinctions -- the believers among the People of the Book ("among the People of the Book is a community standing, reciting the verses of Allah in the night" -- 3:113 stands as the Book's ruling elsewhere) and the claimers of the distortions. The Surah of Tawbah -- the surah of the accounts' settling -- settles the sonship-claim's account in the middle of the Book-era's religious landscape: the two communities' claims named, the claims' lineage traced to the earlier nations, and the turning away from the tawhid condemned with the Book's strongest words -- and the believer who reads the verse in its surah reads it as the ruling it was: the clarion against the distortion, in the surah of the clarions, for the community that would guard the tawhid against every version of the claim. The surah's own name is the verse's own register: Tawbah -- the return -- the surah that calls the claimers back, and the exclamation of the verse is the call's edge: the Lord's severity in the service of the Lord's mercy, the war on the saying that the sayers might return to the truth, and the return that the surah's name keeps as the standing hope for every community that has said with the mouth what the Book never taught.